conceptual categories, no firm foundation we can reach beyond them. Thus, he suggested, we are limited by our lived experience and interpretive abilities. When we realize this, it has profound implications for us. As our illusions fall away, we begin to regard ourselves as contingent beings, inextricably steeped in a reality that we shape and which in turn shapes us, rather than as beings able to detach ourselves to contemplate reality as it 'truly' is (the so-called 'view from nowhere' implicit in the concept of Brahman, or 'Ultimate Reality', of Advaita Vedanta). Such a cognitive shift, according to the Buddha, is a prerequisite for inner peace and wisdom. It grounds us in pragmatic concerns and is conducive to cultivating compassion for our fellow beings who share this world with us.

In shunyata, Nagarjuna's real achievement was a rigorous analysis of phenomena in order to reveal the incoherence of the idea that things possess an 'intrinsic nature'—an eternal existence that does not depend on anything external to it. Nor is there a Self, with an unchanging, innate essence. Instead, the Self is our own conceptual construct, with which we refer to a set of shifting psychophysical states. That we rarely see things this way is a highly pragmatic self-deception that helps us survive. We can, however, recognize this and attain the right self-awareness through continuous practice. Though the Buddha first articulated these views, in Nagarjuna's time they were considered with suspicion. Nagarjuna's careful exposition (and extension) of these views made them respectable again, and they soon became the bedrock of Mahayana Buddhism.

What theory of knowledge can work with the idea of dependent origination or 'emptiness'? A contextualist one, says Nagarjuna, in which investigative procedures are a means of knowledge only in given contexts. To Nagarjuna, our knowledge and concepts, categories and means of investigation, feed on each other. They mutually shape and justify each other in specific contexts, and rely, above all, on us reaching a reflective equilibrium about them. Or as philosopher Richard Rorty put it, 'Truth is what your contemporaries let you get away with saying.'

Nagarjuna thus leads us to the idea that we can't know the 'ultimate truth' about how things really are; rather, there is only conventional, or generally accepted, truth, one that exists within the context of our commonly accepted practices and beliefs. That said, not every conventional truth is equally valid, Nagarjuna clarifies, and some can be judged better